Jewish militants. The graffiti looked too stylized, they said, not like the rough cursive Hebrew hastily scrawled at the scene of other arsons. “Something here is very fishy,” one settler told *Arutz Sheva* after he joined a left-wing group for a condolence visit to the village.[1] This was reminiscent of the rumor-mongering that followed Abu Khdair’s murder, when voices on the right suggested that it was an “honor killing”—that his family murdered him for being gay. (This was nonsense: after a long investigation, the police indicted two Israeli Jews for the attack.)

As Israeli society has become more nationalist and religious, it has given rise to several extremist groups that deliberately work to fan the flames of Jewish-Arab hatred. One of the most notorious is Lehava. The group’s name is an acronym for *LeMeniat Hitbolelut B’eretz HaKodesh* (For the Prevention of Assimilation in the Holy Land) though the word *lehava* also means “flame” or “blaze” in Hebrew. The Knesset has debated whether to ban Lehava as a terrorist organization, with one lawmaker comparing it to the so-called Islamic State. Its main focus is miscegenation: marriage between Jews and Arabs. Even if you believe this is a problem, it is not a significant one. In a country of 8.4 million, the number of Jewish-Arab marriages is thought to number in the hundreds. A 2016 Pew poll found that 98 per cent of married Jewish Israelis have Jewish spouses. 89 per cent said they were uncomfortable with the idea of their children marrying a Christian, and 97 per cent with a Muslim. Nonetheless, the group operates a hotline which Israelis can call to report a mixed relationship. “If you know a girl who is involved with a *goy* and want to help her, press 2.”

In 2014, Lehava gathered a mob to chant “death to Arabs” outside a mixed wedding in Jaffa. On Thursday nights, dozens of Lehava activists clad in black T-shirts fan out across Jerusalem’s city center. Some of them harass couples that appear “mixed” and hand out pamphlets warning about the dangers of assimilation. Others chase after Palestinians, yelling racial epithets and, occasionally, attacking them. Police have logged at least twenty such assaults over the past few years. Nobody has been arrested. The group also organized a protest at the lighting of the municipal Christmas tree in Jerusalem in 2015. “Christmas has no place in the Holy Land,” said the group’s leader, Bentzi Gopstein, who called Christians “blood-sucking vampires.” Three members of Lehava were convicted of setting fire to a bilingual Jewish-Arab school in Jerusalem.